

Picture Wall — Damage and Causes

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1. Basic Facts

- Subject: The causes of deterioration affecting the Picture Wall (Deewar-e-Jahangiri)
- Time period affected: Primarily the British colonial period onward
- Cost of damage: Not quantifiable / not documented
- Relevant to: Understanding why large-scale restoration became necessary by the early 2000s

2. Construction Details

- Not applicable — this entry concerns damage and deterioration mechanisms rather than original construction.

3. Historical Background

- Deterioration was driven largely by disruption to the original Mughal water-drainage system: waterspouts installed during the British period discharged monsoon rainwater in a pattern very different from the wall's original Mughal-era drainage design.
- This altered water flow caused deep erosion of the tile and fresco surfaces over time, compounded by biofilm growth (organic growth on damp surfaces), glaze loss on individual tiles, and general weathering from over a century of exposure.
- The cumulative deterioration was serious enough to be a contributing factor in Lahore Fort's placement on the UNESCO List of World Heritage in Danger around 2000.

4. Interesting Facts / Trivia

- The root cause was not simply "old age" but a specific, identifiable engineering change - new British-era waterspouts redirecting water in a way the original 17th-century design never anticipated - a reminder that even well-intentioned colonial-era infrastructure additions could unintentionally damage centuries-old craftsmanship.

5. Scenario / Narrative Moment

No single dramatic event damaged the Picture Wall - just decade after decade of monsoon water running down the wrong path, one rainy season at a time, until a wall built to display Mughal grandeur for centuries started quietly losing its colour one tile at a time.